had written off their investment in the company. Even if these rumours cannot be verified, there is little doubt that the SSNCo's rivals tried their best to demoralize its supporters by spreading them.[48]

Calls for Support, Canvassing for Shares

In the face of this crisis, SSNCo and its backers redoubled the efforts to put the company on an even keel. They tried to assuage fears of its collapse and promised a turnaround. Despite the cut-throat competition, SSNCo rightly claimed to have the overwhelming support of 'a large majority of the merchants—almost the entire body' in shipping cargo. The passenger traffic, the company conceded, was a different matter. BI's special arrangement with the South India Railway for seamless passenger travel and the compact with the Ceylon government for plantation labour made its position in passenger traffic unassailable. Unless SSNCo could run an uninterrupted daily service, it could hardly hope to negotiate a deal with the Ceylon government.[49] SSNCo also believed that it would have to incur more losses unless BI was forced 'to come to some reasonable terms'.[50]

The nationalist press jumped to SSNCo's support and rallied the public. Not content with publishing regular reports on the Swadeshi company, *The Hindu* carried a lead editorial wherein it sought to give a positive spin.[51] Describing SSNCo, quite accurately, as 'practically the first of its kind, in this part of the country at any rate', it praised the company for 'usher[ing] in the germs of a national mercantile marine—a fact of importance in the building up of a national system of industry in this country'. And this, it had done 'against the greatest odds'. Praising the merchants of Tuticorin and their advisers, it said, '[m]en possessed of less patriotism and self-sacrifice' would have quickly given up. Pointing out the 'ugly partiality' of the joint magistrate of Tuticorin in describing the rival BI as 'the richest company in Asia', the daily said this was hardly surprising; as though BI's 'long experience in shipping and de facto possession of the field were not enough', it was also able to command the 'aid of the executive at its pleasure'. Yet, the Swadeshi company, far from being discouraged, was 'in